Captain's Guide

companion page for the Meal Drop-Off Instructions card

This little card is the etiquette section of the whole meal train, and it's the difference between help that feels like help and help that feels like a visit nobody had the energy to host. Print one per volunteer and hand it out with the sign-up sheet.

Why the cooler-and-porch routine matters

— A cooler on the porch means a volunteer can complete the favor without a single schedule negotiation. It's the most exhausting part of receiving help — hosting the helper — quietly solved.

— The knock-don't-ring rule protects naps, painkillers, and bad afternoons. People want to say thank you in person; let the family do that on their own clock, in a text.

— The photo text is the secret hero move: "Soup and rolls are in the blue cooler, ice packs in." Sixty seconds of effort, zero confusion.

Setting it up takes ten minutes

— Put a cooler on the porch on day one of the train. That's the whole infrastructure project.

— Fill the back of the card in once and photocopy it — never ask every volunteer for the same address details.

— If there's no cooler, say so on the card and name a plan B: closed bag out of the sun, no perishables left long.

Gentle gotchas

— Some volunteers will want to stay and chat. They're being loving, but hand them the card anyway; the printed routine gives everyone kindness with an exit built in.

— Remind the family the routine isn't coldness — it's the thing that lets ten people feed them without ten conversations.

This card is quiet love in protocol form: drop, knock, text, gone. It tells everyone who shows up exactly how to be gentle — and it lets the family just… eat.